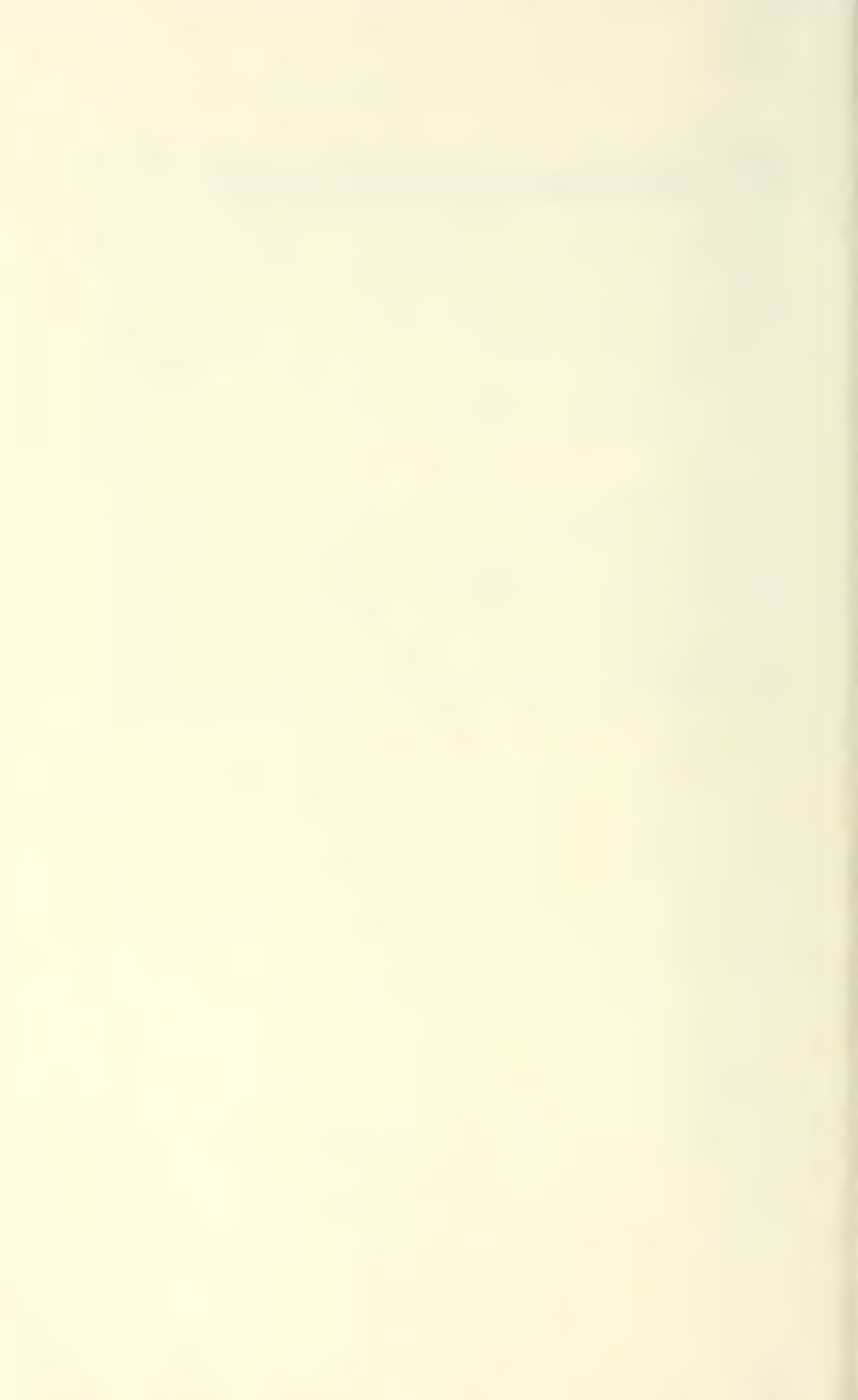




1 Defining the Subject

Not too many years ago it was part of the received wisdom that the history of scientific or philosophical subjects was entirely distinct from the subject itself; that there is the *doing* of psychology, sociology, economics, physics, etc., and then there is the *history* of such fields. We know better now. Although there are still important differences to be noted, we are more prepared to acknowledge that all intellectual pursuits arise within, and to some extent must bear the marks of, their historical and cultural contexts. This is so not only for the obvious reason that major issues are generally bequeathed rather than suddenly born, but also because the entire enterprise of creating knowledge and solving problems of a given kind is itself a continuing tradition, a culture in its own right. This does not prevent the development of new fields and modes of inquiry, nor does it deny the occasional genius a chance to fashion the unexpected. Rather, it is this culture of knowledge, this culture of thought, that comes to establish the very standards of novelty and usefulness and proceeds to confer meaningfulness and significance on just such efforts.

To refer to a “culture of knowledge” is to introduce a set of traditions that transcend ethnic, national, religious, and racial distinctions, traditions that may be said to pertain to something close to our basic humanity. Indeed, free and imaginative inquiry, seemingly idle speculation, argument and spirited discourse, the play of the mind—these are so central to what we take to be part of a flourishing life that we pity or condemn societies and governments unwilling to permit or nurture such activities.

Psychology as a discipline and as a profession is one of the creations of the culture of thought. Just how it was brought about, how the psychological life of individual persons was objectified and externalized and thus made a subject of study, forms an important chapter in the cluttered book of human initiative. But in its current form, psychology is so various, so partitioned into separate provinces, that the nonspecialist might pardonably conclude that there is